

GOING BEYOND IN SERVING GOD, THE CHURCH AND THE COMMUNITY

TEXT: Romans 12:1 (NKJV) *"I beseech you therefore, brethren, by the mercies of God, that you present your bodies a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable to God, which is your reasonable service."*

Matthew 25:37-40 (NKJV) *"Then the righteous will answer Him, saying, 'Lord, when did we see You hungry and feed You, or thirsty and give You drink? 38 'When did we see You a stranger and take You in, or naked and clothe You? 39 'Or when did we see You sick, or in prison, and come to You?' 40 'And the King will answer and say to them, 'Assuredly, I say to you, inasmuch as you did it to one of the least of these My brethren, you did it to Me.'"*

Matthew 23:10-12 (KJV) *"Neither be ye called masters: for one is your Master, even Christ. 11 But he that is greatest among you shall be your servant. 12 And whosoever shall exalt himself shall be abased; and he that shall humble himself shall be exalted."*

INTRO: Our society is geared toward leadership rather than serving. Everywhere you turn you see a new best-selling book or a conference being advertised, all having to do with leadership. John Maxwell said, *"Everything rises and falls on leadership."* I am certainly not in a position to dispute Mr. Maxwell but I believe the bedrock of our effectiveness is tied to what Jesus said in Matthew 23:10-12 (KJV) *"Neither be ye called masters: for one is your Master, even Christ. 11 But he that is greatest among you shall be your servant. 12 And whosoever shall exalt himself shall be*

abased; and he that shall humble himself shall be exalted."

Someone said *"He who bows lowest, stands the tallest."* Jesus not only preached and taught servant-hood but He modeled it as well. Everywhere Jesus went He found a way to serve the people:

- He preached in their Synagogues...
- He taught them valuable lessons...
- He healed the sick...

Most of us have become saturated with lessons on how to be a good leader, what we need is to figure out how to incorporate a little servant-hood with it. Servant leadership is the most effective kind of leadership. Pastors and lay leaders alike should be willing to get their hands dirty in the work of God, right along with the people they are leading. Being a good leader will not release us from our God-given responsibility of serving God's people.

GOING BEYOND IN COVENANT TO SERVE - BY DEMONSTRATING GOD'S LOVE FOR OTHERS

1 Peter 4:10 (NLV) *"God has given each of you a gift. Use it to help each other. This will show God's love."*

The Bible makes very clear the love of God for all the people of this world. John 3:16 (KJV) *"For God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have everlasting life."*

When Jesus left the earth He gave His followers a mandate. John 14:12 (NKJV) *"Most assuredly, I say to you, he who believes in Me, the works that I do he will do also; and greater works than these he will do, because I go to My Father."*

There is no greater way to manifest the love of our Heavenly Father than to love someone who does not deserve it! Matthew 5:46 (NKJV) *“For if you love those who love you, what reward have you?”*

I covenant to serve Him and others for the purpose of demonstrating His love for others! (I pray every day that as I reach out and touch the people of this church that when I pull my hands back, they will have the fingerprints of God on their life because He has touched them through me!)

GOING BEYOND IN COVENANT TO SERVE - BY DEMONSTRATING THE ABILITIES GOD HAS GIVEN US

Each of us was born with certain abilities. These abilities are normally referred to as our natural gifts. God gives us our natural abilities at birth because He has something specific in mind for us to do with our lives. Psalm 139:13-16 (LB) *"You made all the*

delicate, inner parts of my body and knit them together in my mother's womb. 14 Thank you for making me so wonderfully complex! It is amazing to think about. Your workmanship is marvelous—and how well I know it. 15 You were there while I was being formed in utter seclusion! 16 You saw me before I was born and scheduled each day of my life before I began to breathe. Every day was recorded in your book!"

When we accept Christ, God gives us a host of spiritual gifts that will work in tandem with our natural abilities, catapulting us into a position of achieving His destiny for our lives. Ephesians 2:10 (NKJV) *"For we are His workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand that we should walk in them."*

God takes very seriously the manner in which we use our gifts and abilities. He

gave us the gifts and abilities we possess to do a very specific work for Him. Luke 12:48 (NKJV) ***“For everyone to whom much is given, from him much will be required; and to whom much has been committed, of him they will ask the more.”***

When we function in the specific role He has pre-determined for us, we demonstrate the fact that our gifts and abilities are not really our own, they are His. When we reach the point of serving in our place, we will experience the anointing of the Holy Spirit and the favor of the Lord. When this happens we are able to accomplish feats that are phenomenal.

Someday we will all give an account for what we did with what we had. Romans 14:12 (NKJV) ***"So then each of us shall give account of himself to God."***

I wish to serve my Father, my fellow believers and my community for the purpose of demonstrating His ability, not mine!

GOING BEYOND IN COVENANT TO SERVE - BY DEMONSTRATING OUR FAITH AND COMMITMENT TO GOD

We have a tendency to constantly focus on what we can get rather than what we can give. To the modern church God has become a giant Santa Claus in the sky. We want to know, what is in this for me? The Mission and Purpose statement of the modern church seems to be "*Gimme... Gimme... Gimme...*" We are strong on getting but weak on serving!

The late President John F. Kennedy said, "*Ask not what your country can do for you, but what you can do for your country.*"

The most effective way to demonstrate our faith and commitment to the Lord is through service to Him. It is impossible for one

human being to serve another on an ongoing basis without loving them and being fully committed to them. When most of us got married we were more in lust than love. Lust can drive your desire to be romantic with your spouse but it takes love to change their diaper if necessary.

What constitutes serving the Lord?

- Our worship is an act of service
- Our giving is an act of service
- Living a godly life is an act of service
- Ministering to others is an act of service

Listen to what Paul told Timothy.

1 Timothy 4:14-16 (NLT) ***"Do not neglect the spiritual gift you received through the prophecies spoken to you when the elders of the church laid their hands on you. 15 Give your complete attention to these matters. Throw yourself into your tasks so that everyone will see your progress. 16 Keep a close watch on yourself and on your teaching. Stay true to what is right, and***

God will save you and those who hear you."

We must covenant to serve the Lord, His church and the community to demonstrate our faith in Him, and commitment to Him!

CONCLUSION:

Serving God and serving His Church introduces great satisfaction in the life of His servants! Let us covenant with one another before God today to:

- Serve God...
- Serve each other...
- Serve this community...

FACILITATOR'S QUESTIONS:

- Who is called to serve? (Everyone)
- Why do we need to serve? (To demonstrate God's love for others – To demonstrate our God given gifts and abilities – To demonstrate our faith and commitment to God)

- Who do we need to serve? (The Lord – Other believers – The community)
- What is Christian ministry? (Serving God – Believers – Community)
- What is our motivation for service? (Love for God – Love for our fellow believers – Love for the community)
- Who did Jesus say would be greatest in the Kingdom of God? (The one who is servant to all)